

Not having suffered the reverses that Johnston and Taylor had known, Kirby Smith proved less willing to come to terms. On the day after Taylor's capitulation, he flatly refused a Union invitation to lay down his arms. On May 12 and 13, a final engagement was fought at Palmito Ranch, a Confederate outpost on the Rio Grande. Twice the position fell to attacking Union regiments, and twice the defenders reclaimed it. Ironically, it was the Confederates who thus won the last battle of the Civil War, at a cost of four men killed and a dozen or more wounded—the Union force suffered 30 casualties.

A three-man detachment in Virginia's Great Dismal Swamp are believed to have been the last Confederate soldiers to lay down their arms. They finally emerged in July 1866, 15 months after Lee's surrender.



The surrender of Johnston

Confederate General Johnston (on the right) surrenders to General Sherman on April 26, 1865. The two men became firm friends, and a quarter of a century later Johnston was a pallbearer at Sherman's funeral.